

Checklist

Engineering Executive: Job Search

Decide Whether to Pursue an Executive Role

- ☐ Clearly articulate **why you want** an executive role
- ☐ Ensure your **rationale is positive** (growth, impact, learning — not ego or status)
- ☐ **Pressure-test** your reasoning with trusted peers/mentors
- ☐ Confirm you're **motivated** by the work — not just the title

Prepare for a “One-of-One” Search

- ☐ Accept that executive searches are unstructured and variable
- ☐ Avoid over-generalizing from past interview experiences
- ☐ Recognize that confidence is common — discern substance from bravado
- ☐ Expect role definitions to vary significantly across companies

Finding Roles

Internal

- ☐ Evaluate realistically whether internal promotion makes sense
- ☐ Consider political dynamics and peer relationships
- ☐ Assess whether you'll receive adequate support in transition
- ☐ Understand internal transitions may be harder than external ones

External

- ☐ Strengthen and activate your professional network
- ☐ Build relationships with executive recruiters

- ☐ Maintain an updated LinkedIn profile
- ☐ Respond thoughtfully and professionally to recruiter outreach
- ☐ Seek warm introductions via investors, founders, or operators
- ☐ Don't rely solely on recruiters (best roles often never reach them)
- ☐ Be cautious about roles publicly posted — investigate context

Interview Process

General Preparation

- ☐ Prepare to be evaluated on fit, communication, and perceived leadership
- ☐ Show energy and authentic excitement for the company
- ☐ Use structured storytelling (e.g., STAR method)
- ☐ Send timely, thoughtful follow-ups

Interview Stages

- ☐ Recruiter screen: clarify expectations, logistics, and concerns
- ☐ CEO/executive call: demonstrate preparation and strategic thinking
- ☐ Deep founder discussions: assess mutual working fit
- ☐ Meet peer executives and key team members
- ☐ Prepare a clear, structured executive presentation (vision + first 90 days)

Presentation

- ☐ Focus on high-impact priorities
- ☐ Leave time for discussion
- ☐ Ask what has worked well in past candidate presentations
- ☐ Align your plan with company priorities

Negotiating the Contract

Compensation

- ☐ Benchmark compensation with peers
- ☐ Review comparable public executive compensation (if applicable)
- ☐ Clarify base, bonus structure, and equity details

Equity

- ☐ Understand form (options, RSUs, etc.)
- ☐ Review vesting schedule and cliffs
- ☐ Negotiate vesting terms if appropriate
- ☐ Understand post-termination exercise window
- ☐ Evaluate tax implications with an advisor

Acceleration

- ☐ Clarify single vs. double trigger acceleration
- ☐ Understand acquisition/change-of-control scenarios

Severance

- ☐ Negotiate severance terms upfront
- ☐ Confirm severance duration and conditions

Bonus

- ☐ Clarify bonus size and structure
- ☐ Understand individual vs. shared goal metrics

Other Terms

- ☐ Negotiate parental leave terms (if relevant)
- ☐ Agree on a realistic start date
- ☐ Negotiate role support (e.g., executive assistant, hiring budget)
- ☐ Don't over-negotiate to the point of damaging trust

Deciding Whether to Accept

- ☐ Spend sufficient time with the CEO
- ☐ Ensure you trust their leadership and judgment
- ☐ Speak with at least one board member
- ☐ Meet every executive you'll regularly work with
- ☐ Review the company's recent financials (P&L)
- ☐ Confirm your key questions have been fully answered

- ☐ Investigate recent executive departures
- ☐ Be willing to walk away if something feels off
- ☐ Ask yourself:
 - Am I still excited?
 - Can I see myself thriving here?
 - Have trusted advisors validated this decision?

If You Don't Get the Job

- ☐ Reframe rejection as filtering toward a better fit
- ☐ Remember: the goal is not *an* executive job — it's the *right* one
- ☐ Maintain relationships even when processes end